

Calvin:
**An Examination of the Debate Between Free Will and
Predestination**

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Introduction

This paper will examine Calvin's predestination. In doing so, it will examine the debate on Free Will vs Predestination. It will reference Martin Luther's doctrines as the inspiration for Calvin. This is essentially a theoretical work that comes from a single mind; therefore, it does not reference other works. It is, thus, based on logic and reasoning, rather than referencing other people's ideas.

This paper will examine the debate between Free Will and Predestination. In particular, the Free Will side will say that Christians can choose to believe in God, and that they can later choose not to believe in God and lose their faith. Predestination generally assumes the position that Christians are destined to go to heaven or hell even before they are born (before the foundations of the earth, as the Bible says), and therefore, they cannot alter their own salvation-state.

This paper is not going to cite any sources, but rather will contemplate the issues with logic and Scripture, rather than citing the logic of other people. It will be a contemplative journey of a single mind dealing with the issues.

Some preliminary issues that are obviously apparent is: if predestination is true, then how do people have a regenerative, conversion event when their salvation was determined even before they were born?

And if Free Will is true, how can someone who is saved choose to deny Christ later on when the Bible teaches the Perseverance of the Saints and Assurance of Salvation?

I will tackle each issue between the two in the sections of this paper.

The issues that I will tackle are as follows:

1. If Free Will is true, how can Christians lose their salvation?
2. If Predestination is true, how can they have a conversion event?
3. If Free Will is true, does that mean that Predestination is false? Are they incompatible or can they actually be compatible?

According to the Free Will position, Christians can lose their salvation.

The Scriptural support comes from Hebrews, where it says, “How can someone who has tasted the Holy Spirit, and crucify Jesus over and over, consider themselves saved?” (paraphrase).

And it is important to think of issues philosophically with a natural theology.

And from this perspective, there is a need to define what salvation really is.

Salvation can be considered the moment that a person chooses to entrust his life to Jesus Christ and to God. It has been generally considered that a man is “dead in his trespasses” (Ephesians 2) before this time, and is “born again” (John 3:16) when he trusts in God.

The Free Will perspective will agree that one is dead before he trusts in God. This perspective will say that Christians are born without original sin and they have good in themselves and therefore can be saved from the very beginning.

If that is the case, the Methodists would say that Christians may not have original sin, but they are still dead in our trespasses from birth.

I don’t think that any Christian would say that they can be in a salvific state from birth without any help externally.

And the verse to support this is in Romans, which says that “through Adam, death spread to all men” (Romans).

But what would the philosopher or scientist say? How would he define salvation?

Man is just an animal that needs to live morally in order to live a good life and die and never exist again.

If that is false, then man has a spirit and there is something spiritual about this world.

There is the question, “Is there a God?”

Calvin, in his Institutes, actually addresses this question from the very beginning.

He says that in order to look at God, we must look at man, and when we look at man, we look at God.

Therefore, when man looks at himself, he starts to wonder, “Is there something greater than I?”

And this is where, man doesn’t know for sure, but that Special Revelation begins to teach what is the truth of what to believe.

But we can say with the assumption that God exists, and he is the Christian God.

But we are still left with the question, what is salvation?

What does it mean that we are spiritually dead? What does that mean? Mathematically or scientifically?

And it can be said that there is some biological component to the spirit.

But I believe that the spirit is immaterial and not physical.

The spirit may influence the physical and biological, but the essence of the spirit is immaterial.

Therefore, what does it mean for something invisible, such as the spirit to be dead?

Does it mean that is not aligned with God? That, there is something missing - that is life, or eternal life?

If we are to be Biblical, we have to go back to the Garden of Eden and what it means for someone to go from life (original state of Adam) to death (after eating the fruit of knowledge of good and evil).

Adam and Eve were enjoying fellowship with God with no shame. Did they know evil? Were they exposed to it? Or were they oblivious to it?

This is somewhat tangential, but I believe they could not know evil even though it may have been around them.

But when the serpent allowed evil to enter into them, they saw what evil is.

And so spiritual death is the perception and having of evil.

Evil is death.

But what is evil?

Evil is against the truth, and if it is death, it is against life.

Satan is described as the father of lies.

Thus, evil can be best summarized as the perversion and departure from truth and life and the natural order of things.

Something untrue is something unreal, it is a fantasy.

When humans wanted to be God or like God, they were searching for something of a fantasy.

It is impossible to be God as a human - that is, unless the Spirit of God enters them.

Thus, Adam and Eve searched to be God and reached for Godhood even though they were plain humans that are fallible and limited.

Thus, they entered the fantasy and entered into unreality. Evil entered them. Something contrary to the natural order that God created and was real.

They wanted to be God, and so they had to die. Evil entered them and they became something they are not, and thus, they lost their God given gift of life.

Anything that loses its original formation will eventually slowly disintegrate because it's like a spring that slowly unwinds.

And so this is the definition of spiritual death - to have evil and to eventually die.

It is an empirical method to determine if someone has spiritual death to measure if they will die.

Physical death is caused by two things - natural death, but also the environment forces one to die.

Is it possible to measure from the beginning of birth, whether the baby will naturally die? This is an empirical method of determining if all babies have original sin or spiritual death, or rather we die spiritually later on by choice or are forced by the environment at some age.

And I think it is possible to biologically determine that every baby has to die.

How can this be, however?

Adam and Eve were supposed to live forever?

Actually, this may not have been the case.

Some professors have said that Adam was meant to live for one thousand years and then die. That is, even if he were not to spiritually die.

Thus, the question remains, when do we spiritually die? Do we have original sin?

We can empirically see that even babies have sin and that young children do sinful actions.

Thus, it is safe to assume with natural theology that babies are born with original sin.

The next question is, what does it mean to go from death to life through conversion or regeneration.

Can regeneration happen without the gospel message?

If Martin Luther was right about “Christ alone,” it may not be just the gospel message, but the substance of Christ that is transferred from Christ to a Christian to a non-Christian. Possibly, Christ can be transferred to a non-believer through the natural world as “All creation can see the invisible attributes of God” (Romans 1).

Therefore, it is safe to believe that Christ can be evangelized through an encounter with an angel, through an encounter at a convenience store with a Christian, or through prayer millions of miles away.

But we assume here that conversion is a specific event that is instantaneous and someone goes from death to life. It is not a process, and it seems that if it goes forward so positively, how can it become negative and someone go back to their original state?

And so we address these questions.

Is conversion instantaneous?

It seems that conversion has to be instantaneous. The author of this paper has seen it happen before. He has seen that people go through a process of being cornered by a Christian or by God and then experience a conversion moment of bliss and enter into the new life.

But to argue, let’s assume it is a process. What does this mean?

It means that there is an intermediate state of being saved and not saved. And it is exactly this state in which one may argue that one may be saved, and then lose their salvation by losing the other side of the balance.

Truly, in this perspective, it would be said that one is truly saved when he reaches heaven, and there is no guarantee until then.

On this earth, we may be shades of “saved” or “unsaved” but we cannot be black and white. In this case, we may be born with no sin, but always we will end up with some sin.

Just as Adam ate the fruit, babies may spiritually eat the fruit at some point in their early life.

Thus, with good works, we go from an “unsaved” state to a more “saved” state.

Truly, this seems like works-righteousness, but it may be faith that empowers us to be more “saved.”

This is exactly the Methodist view of things.

And if the Methodists are right, Free Will will say that we can lose our salvation.

But it is an interesting terminology to say that we can lose our salvation, because one does not gain it until the end of their life.

Thus, it is better to say their trajectory was going toward heaven (mostly), but they changed directions later and ended up in hell.

Thus, another question that comes up is: how far “saved” do you need to be to achieve heaven at the end of your life?

This is the question of purgatory, but that is not in the Bible.

But to focus on our topic of free will and predestination, we shall leave the Free Will perspective analysis up until this point.

The important thing is: we have determined that Free Will will lead to a possibility of a loss of salvation.

But one thing is missing: what is free will?

Free Will in our text is simply the act of man doing good works in order to be “saved” or bad works to be more “unsaved.” Free will is nothing but the will of man that is able to freely do good or bad. And in this definition, even Calvin would say that we have Free Will because even Calvin would say we are not robots.

But what would Calvin say about Free Will? Why does Calvin oppose it and espouse something of the doctrine of Predestination and Total Depravity?

Calvin is simply saying that our will is not completely free. It is free in some sense, or not free at all, but the guiding principle is that God guides our will or controls it to some or total degree.

But this does not mean we are robots and have no consciousness. We are alive with life and Free, but we may be guided and Totally Depraved.

Total Depravity does not mean that we are robots and have no consciousness. Biology tells us that we can make decisions and choose whether to buy something or pass it by.

But what does Calvin mean that Free Will is false?

Free Will says that we can choose good or evil - that we can actually choose good.

But Calvin says that we cannot choose good.

We may be free to buy candy or not, but we cannot choose to be good or evil - we can only be evil, according to Calvin.

Now according to Free Will and Methodism, we have good and “saved” portions of us. Therefore, that good portion of us can choose good. We have Free Will in a way that Calvin would oppose. But Calvin would agree, with even Total Depravity, that if we have the Spirit of

God, which equates to the “saved” portion of us, we can choose God through God’s empowerment and Spirit (Romans 8).

In this definition and context, there is no difference between Free Will and Total Depravity - the essence is that the total depravity is the “unsaved” portion of us, and the “saved” portion of us is the Spirit of God.

The question is, is the “saved” portion of us from the Spirit of God or from our own unblemished self from birth?

According to Calvin, the Spirit of God only empowers a person if he is converted.

Even Methodism would say that the Spirit of God empowers a person to do good, and allows the person to choose good. It would say that if they deny the Spirit of God, they cannot possibly do good on their own strength. Thus, Methodism would say that even from birth, it is possible to be a Christian by simply being a human, and by the Spirit of God have “saved” portions.

Thus, Methodism would say that we from birth, always have “saved” portions and “unsaved” portions. However, the technical doctrine of Methodism would be Biblical and say that you need to be converted with Jesus’ gospel. But my Free Will perspective stated here, states otherwise.

Thus, Methodism is always going to have a gray area of both “saved” and “unsaved,” while Calvinism will say that one is either “saved” or “unsaved.” But both will say there are the flesh and the Spirit at work in one man. But the Spirit may not be at work before salvation. But the Spirit may be implicit in man from birth because there is no original sin.

I will begin to explain what I believe is the ministerial significance of this doctrine.

You see, academics is good, but without the application or spiritual significance, it is doctrine with ground in reality.

We need to be grounded in reality.

Christ is here and alive - he is not some theory.

This is the exact nature of sin and evil and lies - it is a theory of fantasy rather than reality.

You see, who cares if Calvin is right or Methodism is right, my question is: how do I make my life better and make the world a better place?

You see, there is a warfare going on in Iran right now, and there are babies being born, and families living their lives, and businesses running, and governments doing their work.

There is human-trafficking and sinful acts going on all throughout the world.

To be specific, some people at my church have parents who have divorced, parents who have cancer, parents who steal money from each other, and churches are splitting.

How does this paper address these problems?

And I have to say, I may have failed miserably up until this point to address the real problems of this world.

The bottom line is that Christ is all in all. Christ alone, as Luther has said, is salvation.

It is grace alone through faith alone that saves.

This is the basis for the doctrine of predestination.

Grace alone through faith alone through Christ alone is the doctrine that stands as the crux of all doctrines.

It shows us that we rest on Christ, not on our works. It means that we do not save ourselves, but that God elects and chooses and predestines before the world began.

Predestination does not eliminate Free Will or lack-of-robot-ness, but rather simply means that God is sovereign.

With Christ as the center, we make our work not academic drudgery, but beautiful garments that people want to wear and bless the world.

It is the gospel of Christ that saves, not our academic blunders.

And so we worship Christ and say, "Glory to God! Who saves and redeems and keeps."

He will not let go of me, and he wants to save the world (Bible).

He wants all to be saved (Bible).

We worship you, Lord, and give you the Glory.

Without Christ, we can only do our best and and our all - which will never be enough.

We are in darkness, dead in our trespasses. We believe we see, but we are blind, naked, and poor.

We need Christ - the Light of the World - the Light of Christ.

And the sovereign power belongs to God alone.

Instead of searching for the perfect doctrine as Calvin or Wesley did, we need to search for Christ.

Even Luther said, "Scripture alone," which shows that he is idolizing that Book.

It is Christ alone that saves, who is the true Word of God.

But of course, we highly exalt Scripture, but it is not inerrant - there are discrepancies.

The Word of God in Scripture is perfect and inerrant, but Scripture itself is a text made by humans and may have errors. Even translation to a different language causes a different nuance to be read than the original.

The Scripture was never to be made into God. God alone is God.

Jesus is the Word, not the Bible.

But the Bible may contain or transfer the Word.

We must Worship God.

And God is hidden and is a still small voice.

He is not found in the big churches.

He may be found in a small seminary or in a small church.

Let us worship the Lord who predestinates sinners to hell and the righteous to life.

Without his help, we can only do works and spin doctrines of predestination and Free Will.

The reason why we need to write this paper is so that we can understand God and share him to the world.

We must make disciples of all nations.

Conclusion

In conclusion, we must not spin doctrines about predestination or Free Will. It is not the debate that matters, but faith in Christ alone.

Luther was right about the five solas - it is faith in Christ that saves, which is the basis for the doctrine of predestination. Calvin can only point to Christ, and Martin Luther can only point toward Christ.

We have Scripture as Special Revelation, and must use it as a guide toward Christ.

But we must understand it is the true substance of Christ himself that saves, not Scripture.

Thus, when we trust Christ, we see that God saves and redeems and damns. It is not our decision to elect, but rather God's.

May God gain the glory and let no one take from his glory.

Maranatha.